

Watering the Seed of Your Future

When we get done with you, my friend, you will know how to walk all the way into the perfect plan of God for your life on purpose, just because you want to go in there.

Hallelujah.

Since the Teacher is here, this is a morning to tune your ears. Let's take it a step further.

Romans 12:1 says:

I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.

And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God.

The word "therefore" means that based on something already said, Paul is about to say this. "I beseech you therefore, brethren, based on what I have already said, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service. And be not conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is first the good, then the acceptable, and finally the absolutely perfect will of God."

This much we know: somehow, offering my body as a living sacrifice results in nonconformity to this world and transformation by the renewing of my mind, so that I can find out first the good, then the acceptable, then the perfect will of God.

Mark 4 says it this way: thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and hundredfold. Good, acceptable, and perfect.

The question is, what good, acceptable, and perfect will is Paul talking about? We know he is talking about not being conformed to the world, but being transformed through the renewing of the mind. So we know he is talking about no longer thinking like the world thinks, but being transformed and renewing our mind to think like God and like the Word thinks. We know he is talking about transformation through the Word of God and conformity to it.

But I also know through meditation that he has extended this a step further. When he talks about the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God, he is talking about the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God for our personal lives.

Some people find the good and never leave it. Others find the acceptable and never leave it. But others find the perfect.

I do not mind telling you that at the prayer center, there is something in me that will not live with just good and will not live with just acceptable. If I see more in the Word of God, this thing in me will not rest until we have it. It just cannot.

Many people never find the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God, not because they are not craving and hungry for Him, but because the enemy comes in with deception and stops them. They do not know how to go any further.

There is no worse death I can think of than a slow death of living this life craving, hungering, and thirsting after God, and never being taught or coming to the place where that hunger is quenched. To me, that is a slow, horrible death.

Please, give me my day in court. If I fail, please do not let it be because the truth was never preached to me. If I fail, let it be my decision. Give me my day in court. If I fail, let it be because somebody preached it to me, showed me what to do, showed me how to find this perfect will, and then I rejected it. But do not let me fail because somebody put me in a holding tank and stripped me of truth.

The good, acceptable, and perfect will Paul is talking about operates in two realms.

First, it concerns your personal transformation to the Word of God: healing, righteousness, your walk with God, worship, praise, faith, and all the basic things of faith. It concerns your total transformation into peace.

Second, it concerns the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God for your personal life.

Paul goes on in Romans 12:3:

For I say, through the grace given unto me, to every man that is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think; but to think soberly, according as God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith.

You know the basics of grace. Grace is the unmerited, unearnable favor of God bestowed upon you and me. Paul is about to make a statement based on this unmerited, unearnable favor that he received:

For I say, through the grace given unto me, to every man that is among you...

Then he continues:

For as we have many members in one body, and all members have not the same office:
So we, being many, are one body in Christ, and every one members one of another.
Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us...

In context, is he not saying that you and I are individual members in a vast Body called the Body of Christ? We are members one of another, having gifts that differ from one another, not by our choosing, but by the unmerited, unearnable favor of God.

In eternity past, God separated you and me to our respective calls according to predestination. He gave us an office to fulfill in His Body by grace. As a matter of fact, every man, woman, and child ever born in Alaska, India, Africa, or anywhere else, in God's perfect will, was born to fulfill a respective call in the Body of Christ.

So when Paul says that offering your body as a living sacrifice will result not only in nonconformity to the world, but transformation to God, he is talking about the good, acceptable, and perfect will in the area of your individual call in the vast Body of Christ.

Paul gave some advice in that area. It took me seven years to understand that advice. Then suddenly my lightning-quick mind cleaved to it, and after that measly seven years it dawned on me.

Paul says, "I say to you according to the grace given to me." He is saying, "By the unmerited, unearnable favor bestowed on me, I am about to speak to you out of this grace." He said you ought not to think of yourself more highly than you ought, but you should think soberly, according as God has dealt to every man the measure of faith.

He was saying this: "I have an apostolic office. I was separated to my office, which differs from yours, by the grace of God. So I have grace differing according to the measure God has dealt to me. I am about to speak to you out of the grace given to me, which is my apostolic office: you ought not to think of yourself more highly than you ought."

In other words, it was unmerited, unearnable favor. You did not earn it. So why are you going to think you are something because you are the one up preaching? I am no more something than you sitting in your chair. Helps and governments are just as important as the apostle, the worker of miracles, the teacher, or the pastor. Every one of them is important.

No person ought to think of himself more highly than he ought, because you did not choose your calling. God did, by His unmerited, unearnable grace. So chuck your pride and humble yourself. Your office was given to you by God.

Hallelujah.

Paul says you and I ought not to think of ourselves more highly than we ought. But he gave us the standard to think according to. He said we need to think soberly according as God has dealt to every man the measure of faith.

Here is the standard we are supposed to think by: God has dealt to every man the measure of faith.

Sometimes we get so messed up. I asked those who seemed to be somewhat among them what the measure of faith was. They said, "Well, we are not sure whether it is a measure or the measure."

I thought, What difference does it make? I cannot make either one work.

But who would dare call Jesus Christ a liar? When He moved through Paul and said that you and I have received the measure of faith, this old boy would be the last one on earth to tell Jesus, "I did not receive my measure of faith." I did.

I asked, "What is a measure of faith? Why does He call it a measure? Did Jesus have all faith, and we only have a measure?"

In fact, Paul is talking about the same thing he did in 1 Corinthians 13 when he said that we know in part. That which is perfect will come, and then we will know as we are known. We only have a single part in the Body of Christ to fulfill.

You are not going to be able to operate in my vineyard any more than I can operate in yours. I may not even understand how yours operates, unless perhaps as an apostle I am called to establish all of these ministries. Below an apostolic level, I may not even know how your office operates. I have no business over in your vineyard. That is why God gave you helps, governments, teaching, or whatever your calling is, and gave me mine.

I might operate in the workings of miracles, but God may not have separated you to that office. So how do I know how you feel? We all know in part. One day we will understand the whole operation.

I can tell you why he called it the measure of faith. If you can handle this, it is very deep. Pay attention.

I found out in the second or third grade that if you take a pie and divide it into three measures, that pie now consists of three measures that make one whole. Each measure is one third of the whole. I can get deeper than that, if you can bear it. This is deep calling unto deep.

If you divide a pie in half, it consists of two measures of one half each, and the two measures make one whole. I used to wonder why, when the numbers got bigger, the pieces got smaller. That was the first thing I wondered as a little guy.

Well, I have news for the devil. The Body of Christ consists of many, many measures. Each one of you fills one of those measures. But all the measures working together make one whole, which is a devil-stomping, mountain-moving Body of Christ when it functions together.

I have my measure. You have yours. Helps, governments, counselors, different diversities of tongues, intercessions, levels of intercession, different measures, and different equippings for your office. But all of you have been given a grace. You have been separated to a measure in the Body of Christ, and you have been given a measure of faith.

God has instilled in your spirit enough faith to fulfill your call, not mine, yours. You have the measure of faith. You can finish your course. He has guaranteed it because He deposited it on the inside of your spirit.

Hallelujah. That makes me happy to know I have enough faith. That is what you are going to be judged by.

"Jesus, I did not have enough money to go to Mexico."

He would say, "Now wait a minute. Did I tell you to go?"

"Yes."

"You are right. I did. Why didn't you go?"

"Money."

"You mean your measure did not include enough faith to believe it in?"

God has given every man the measure according to his ability. He gave you the faith to fulfill your call. That is why some of you try to jump out and operate above it, but you cannot. You do not have faith for someone else's call. You have the measure of faith for your call.

The faster you find out what your call is, the faster that faith will begin to work for you. When you are flowing with God, you are not swimming upstream anymore. You are swimming downstream. You can just think Cadillac, and three of them will be in your driveway.

Let's study this measure a little more closely. If I have been given the measure of faith, and God knows I have, and if I have been separated by God, by His grace, to an office that differs from yours, why do so many people flounder around?

They wander almost aimlessly, defeated from one place to another. There is a very small percentage in the Body of Christ that actually fulfills their ministries to full potential. Why is that?

God deposited that measure of faith on the inside of your spirit in seed form. It is like any seed planted along with your rebirth. When God deposited the incorruptible seed on the inside of your spirit, my friend, it carried a diagram and a program like any seed does.

If you take a kernel of corn and crack it open, you may not see a stalk of corn in there, but I can guarantee you the image that corn seed carries is for a whole stalk, with several ears of corn on the stalk. All of that is programmed and diagrammed on the inside of that seed.

When you were born again of incorruptible seed, like any other seed, it carried the program deposited in your spirit. It contained not only what your ministry is to become, but everything He has called you to do. Included in that measure of faith is the ability to receive any blessing redeemed for you through the Cross. All of that is included in the measure of faith.

Not only is your personal call in there, but everything Jesus has made provision for is in there. It is all there for you to believe in. But like any seed, it is deposited in seed form.

Now we are getting back to the basics of prayer.

Jesus said seed was sown on wayside ground, on rocky ground, among thorns, and on good ground. In many instances, it was choked out, took no root, was scorched, and died. Thorns grew up and choked it. Finally, the good ground produced thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and hundredfold. That is good, acceptable, and perfect will again.

Yet the Word of God, the incorruptible seed, and that measure have been deposited inside you.

If your ground is parched and dry, it is hard for the seed to germinate. It can produce very little in your life. If you are caught up in the world, the cares of this world, the lust for other things, and the deceitfulness of riches, the call of God can be choked. It can do very little.

But there is a way to throw water on your seed. The twin sister to watering the seed is meditation of His Word. Meditation, meditation, meditation.

And then the twin sister to that is this:

If you believe on Me, as the Scripture has said, out of your belly shall flow rivers of living water.

How would you like to learn how to water your seed on a daily basis, to cultivate it and pull the weeds out?

God likened the Holy Spirit to water. Every time you pray in tongues, Paul says, "My spirit prays." You are actually throwing water on that seed, germinating, cultivating, and nurturing it so that the image inside it will come out. And that, my friend, includes your call.

Notice that Romans 12 begins, "I beseech you therefore, brethren..." When you see the word "therefore," Kenneth Hagin said you had better find out what it is there for. It means that what Paul is about to say is totally based on something he has already said.

When Paul says, "I beseech you therefore, brethren," he means, "When I ask you to offer your body as a living sacrifice, I would not ask you to do that had I not already told you how to do it in a previous chapter."

That is what "therefore" means.

"I beseech you therefore: go on, offer your body. Receive transformation. Offer your body as a living sacrifice. Find the good, acceptable, and perfect will. Fulfill your grace. Fulfill your call. You have the measure of faith. Go on and do it."

When I see the word "therefore," it makes me want to go back and dig into the previous chapters to find out what Paul based that incredible statement on. I can offer my body as a living sacrifice based on what?

I have tried to do it in the flesh. Have you ever tried to give something up in the flesh? You just decide not to be mad at somebody, and then it comes back on you. There is a better way to do this, and I want to know it.

Hallelujah.

Let's go back to our old friend Romans 8.

"I just can't quit sinning."

Yes, you can.

"No, I can't. You do not live in my body."

Yes, you can. You just think you cannot.

"I can't quit smoking."

Yes, you can.

"No, I really can't."

No, you really can. If you cannot, then the whole Word of God is a lie. You may have to build yourself up because your emotions are so weak that they demand pacification, but you can build yourself to a place where you can. At the same time, you work in the plan of God.

I am telling you, you can. In fact, every one of you can do anything for God if you do not let the devil take you out.

He is after that seed. He wants you sitting somewhere fruitless for the rest of your life. He is after your seed. If I were you, I would not give it to him.

Along with the mysteries we pray in the Holy Ghost, what else are we praying?

Romans 8:21 says:

Because the creature itself also shall be delivered from the bondage of corruption into the glorious liberty of the children of God.

All creation is crying out to God in a form of intercession. Creation is crying out because of its imperfections. Every atom subjected to imperfection by the fall of Adam is crying out before God to be delivered from the bondage of corruption into the glorious liberty of the children of God.

Verse 22 continues:

For we know that the whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now.

Then Paul says:

And not only they, but ourselves also, which have the firstfruits of the Spirit...

Those of us who are born again and filled with the Holy Ghost are also groaning within ourselves, waiting for this entire adoption process of all creation to be completed. We are waiting for our corruptible bodies to be redeemed, for the adoption to be made complete, the redemption of our bodies.

Meanwhile, while we are in an imperfect creation and in a body still capable of sinning, God gave us the Holy Spirit to help our weaknesses and infirmities.

That is what Paul is talking about in Romans 8:26:

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit Himself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.

These are our weaknesses in the flesh, our inability to produce results because of the limitations imposed on us by this body. We do not know what we should pray for as we ought. But the Spirit Himself makes intercession for us with groanings that cannot be uttered.

Then verse 27 says:

And He that searcheth the hearts knoweth what is the mind of the Spirit, because He maketh intercession for the saints according to the will of God.

And verse 28 says:

And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to His purpose.

Let's explore what the Holy Spirit is doing in us when He helps our infirmities.

We want to be delivered immediately from disease and poverty and all these things, and God wants to deliver you. But He wants to do much more than that in your life. He wants to go beyond those things and work God's personal call for you.

That is why Paul says the One who searches the heart knows what is the mind of the Spirit. The word "mind" there means the plan of the Spirit. It is the same plan God, the Holy Spirit, and Jesus sat down in eternity past and planned for all creation and redemption.

He that searches the heart knows the entire plan of God.

Why did Paul say "mind"? Because every generation has a different facet of the plan. You may have a plan for an entire day and a list to start with, but for each hour, you have a specific mind for that hour within the whole plan. Each generation is working toward the entire plan.

When Paul says He that searches the heart knows the entire plan of God, he personalizes it by saying He knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because you are the one involved now. It is God's mind for your personal life in this generation.

The Holy Spirit goes into your heart to search it, already having been with God and knowing the entire plan of creation. But He knows more than that. He knows the mind of God toward this generation, toward Tulsa, toward your individual life. He is the only One qualified to make successful intercession for your life according to the will of God, which is where you fit into His plan, His mind for you.

This means you cannot slip in on Wednesday night, pray two hours in the Holy Ghost, worship for the last thirty minutes, and think nothing is happening because you do not know what you are saying. You do not know what you are saying, but He does.

He knows your ministry to the end of your life. You have a great call. He knows it. He is the only One who knows it. He requires you to walk by faith. You may have a glimpse of the end of your ministry, but your computer would not hold all the particulars between now and then.

In fact, if He told some of you what He wants you to do at the end of your life, you would say, "My God, nobody could do that."

He who searches the heart knows the entire mind and plan of God, and He is making intercession for you as an individual. You cannot pray those two hours in tongues without Him working in you, transforming you to the Word, and working the personal plan of God in your life.

That is why Paul can boldly say:

And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to His purpose.

You can flounder around in the good and acceptable. Whole denominations have been captured by the devil in only the good. They remain saved, keep a testimony, and serve God only to the level of, "I am saved." That is all they do. There is good, there is acceptable, and there is perfect.

But all things will not work together for your good unless you are attempting, one phase at a time, to work His plan for your life. There is no such thing as passively sitting in church doing nothing and being happy. You will go back to the world to supply or satisfy the hunger you have inside. You will either try to kill that hunger, or you will feed it.

Some of you, in the past, have been aboard trains that were not going anywhere. That is why you left. You knew ten years from now you would be doing the same thing.

Hang around here, and I am going to whip you back into prayer every time you get out. A lot of us do not have enough self-discipline to do it because the things of this life are just a little heavier. I will keep whipping you in.

Why? Because I want all things to begin to flow together for good to those who love God and are called according to His purpose.

What is His purpose? The culmination of all things. Does He have a plan toward that end? Yes.

All creation is groaning and travailing for it, and we who have the firstfruits are also groaning inside our righteous spirits. The Holy Spirit is helping our infirmities. We are so limited, yet we have the Holy Spirit. He has the whole plan, not only the whole blueprint, but your life in that plan, so He can work your life according to His purpose.

"You mean praying in tongues is a key?"

Yes, my friend. It is not all the keys, but it is a major key to turning the Holy Spirit loose into your future.

Have you ever bought futures? Have you ever bought stock or a future? "I will buy ten thousand dollars on the futures of corn stock." The reason is that corn may go way down, but you will still get the price you paid now. That is a future.

When you pray in the Holy Ghost, you are purchasing futures. The Holy Spirit is running out ahead of you and working things together for good to those who love God and are called according to His purpose. Why do you think the devil has gotten so many people out of prayer? Go look at them and see what they are doing now.

Let's talk about leadership for a little bit.

Most of us have the concept that the leadership of the Spirit means God comes and attaches Himself to us and wants to lead us in every little aspect, as though we have no free will. You hear some people talk as if they do not even buy a loaf of bread unless the Holy Spirit told them what loaf to buy. They do not get into the car unless He tells them to. They do not do anything unless He tells them to, and then we attempt to call that spirituality.

Let me tell you what spirituality is. Spirituality is a person seasoned in the fruit of the Spirit: longsuffering, forgiveness, peace, righteousness, and understanding.

Does God lead you? Of course He leads me by the Spirit. He talks to me all the time. But He talks to me about things pertaining to the Spirit. He does not care much if I go out on the golf course, and I have not done that in four or five years. He does not talk to me much about whether I am going to make a hole-in-one.

Sometimes we get into super-leadership, and the problem is that most of us are so immature and emotional that we cannot sort out anything. So we get led off into the wild blue yonder, and there goes our lives.

When I began praying in the Holy Ghost in those early days, there were seasons. Sometimes I had to lock up for six or seven hours a day. Other times I was out on the field preaching and would not get to pray much for a month or two. Other times I prayed an hour or two a day. It fluctuated until

God taught me a valuable lesson.

I was condemned half the time because I had not prayed much the previous week. "Is God going to use me this week?" The most amazing thing to me was that one time I went two or three months hardly praying at all, and when I got out there, God used me just as strongly as He did when I was praying much. I thought, I am confused. Why are You doing this?

That is when He taught me one of the most valuable lessons: God does not fellowship very much with the cubicle hours you spend locked away in the prayer closet.

You may think, If I go between 7:00 and 8:00 every morning and lock myself in that cubicle of time, then at 8:00 I come out and feel good about the day. But then Thursday comes, something happens, and Friday morning you do not make it. So you feel condemned that day: "I did not have prayer this morning."

The fellowship He has with your person is not with those cubicle hours. What He fellowships with is the change the prayer produced in your life. If you only prayed one day last year and it produced a little change, He comes in and fellowships with that. He does not condemn you for the times you did not pray.

This is strictly up to you. He lays the reward out ahead of you, but He loves you anyway.

It is the same thing with fasting. When you no longer esteem it as a sacrifice, you will quit bragging about it. He is not fellowshipping with your sacrifice. You may say, "I sacrificed and went without food forty days." He does not delight in sacrifices. He delights in obedience. He will fellowship with what the fasting produced in your life by way of change.

He comes along and says, "Look at this change," and He cleaves to you and fellowships with you over the change. He was not impressed with your sacrifice.

When you quit esteeming fasting as a sacrifice, and quit being proud of your cubicle hours of prayer, you stop running around bragging about them. The only thing God fellowships with is the change they produce. He will take any prayer time you can give Him.

In those early days, as we wind down, I prayed and preached in halls. Sometimes I slept in the car. Fire marshals had run us out. Sometimes I spent a day in the car praying and having a time, just working the plan of God without knowing it.

I kept praying in the Holy Ghost, waiting for leadership to come. I will tell you how it comes: you cannot miss it.

As you keep praying in the Holy Ghost, suddenly the seed germinates. Pretty soon, you can see what kind of seed is coming out. Direction comes in the form of God instilling something in your spirit.

If you are supposed to go and do a work in Mexico, pretty soon that will get dropped in there. It comes out of the seed. You keep praying, and it waters and grows until the feeling is no longer a passing, wimpy thing that makes you say, "I am not sure; I will go counsel with thirty-five people." If you are not sure, do not go.

This thing will take you over and consume you. If you keep praying, eventually you cannot think or even work hardly at anything else until finally you have to pack your bag. Money does not matter. Nothing matters. You have to quench that craving because that direction comes on you and stays. It gets stronger and stronger and stronger until you cannot help but walk in the direction of it.

So you will not miss it unless you get out and become carnal. Then you will miss everything. He will still love you.

It has been a long time since God told me what pair of shoes to wear or what car to take. However, the other day in the office, I opened the curtain after prayer and did not know how to pull it up or get it down. I worked on it for about fifteen minutes, then finally sat down in my chair with the sun beating through the window.

I finally said, "I give up." I kicked back in the chair and said, "God, that curtain."

He said, "Why don't you pull one string at a time?"

I thought, Come on. I pulled it, and it went up. I said, "My God."

So prayer and the leadership of the Spirit come by offering your body as a living sacrifice. He works the plan of God in your personal life by creating a strong anointing.

The Scripture says:

Concerning those that seduce you, ye have no need that any man teach you: but the anointing which ye have received of Him abideth in you, and is truth, and cannot lie, and it shall teach you all things.

You will increase that anointing stronger and stronger until His leadership grows, not only in direction, but also in your call. In other words, My God, I feel like a teacher. I feel workings of miracles in my spirit. They have never gone away in all my years of ministry. I see them. They have never gone away.

You will not have to wonder what He called you to do. It will grow on you like a tree if you remain constant in prayer, worship, and meditation of His Word.

Do not go to a church where they do not whip you back into prayer. You need it.

Do people find the plan of God without this? Sure they do. You can have anything you want from God if you can believe Him for it. I do not care how you get to the place of believing Him. You can do anything for God and go anywhere if He sends you and you have faith. It does not matter how you got there.

I am telling you biblical scriptures and principles for how to take yourself from where you are, on purpose, to where He said you could be.

We are part of a team.

People have stopped coming to the prayer center because they said, "There is more to things than just praying."

Oh, you listen to me. By the time you deliver yourself enough from the flesh so you can work in the programs without causing us any problems, do you think God will ever use you?

"Will He ever use me?"

Use you? My God, He will work you to death. There are not enough of us to go around. Would you please hurry?

Remain faithful. When the direction begins to come, take it. Work in this office, this facet of the church. Present yourself. Begin to work into it.

You can always tell people who are building their career in the Kingdom of God as opposed to those who offer their gift as servants. If you do not exalt them, they bounce around the churches and do not want to come, because they are building their ministry instead of the Body.

Do not say, "I do not blame you for not wanting to be used." I want you to be used. If you think you are not going to be, you had better hang on. Remain faithful a little longer and you will say, "My God."

He will use you. He will work you to death.

But right now you need enough faith to direct your energy in prayer for the present time.